

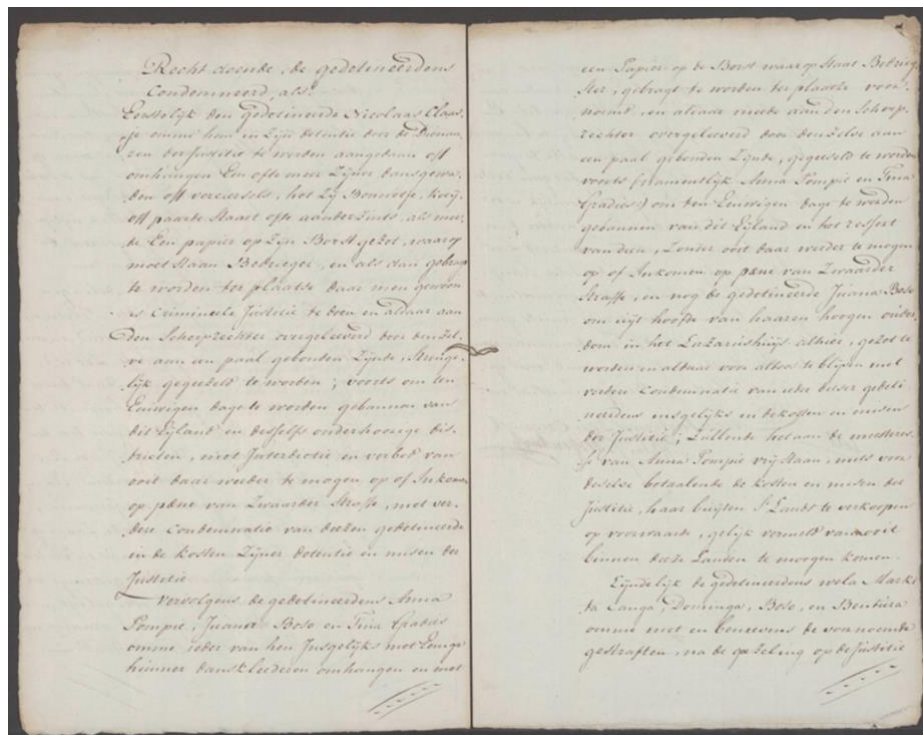
# National Archive: experience the history of Curaçao in VR

*“Revoicing, revisioning, and remediating the National Archive exposition Kòrsou – Curaçao, voices from then, contemporary people.”*

This project was in collaboration with the National Archive as part of the Experience Design for Interaction course. The aim was to develop a virtual reality experience on seventeenth-century Curaçao. Building on the *Kòrsou – Curaçao* exposition (2021–2022), which combined archival materials, oral histories from the Zikinzá collection, and contemporary voices. The VR experience translated these layered perspectives into an immersive format. In close collaboration with Laurindo Andrea of the National Archive, the project delivered a functional VR experience with dedicated on and off-boarding flows. It offered new ways to engage with Curaçao’s colonial history and its silenced narratives.

## 1 Artefact selection

The project began with the selection of a colonial-era document on sorcery and the figure of Wela Markita Kanga, which served as the central artefact inspiring the VR experience.

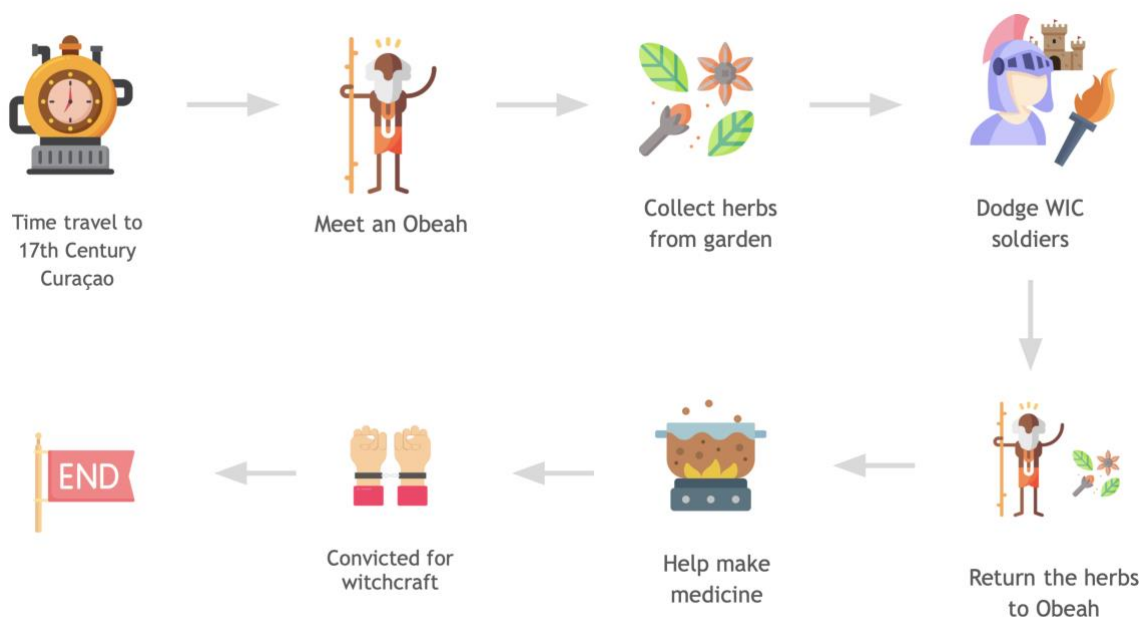


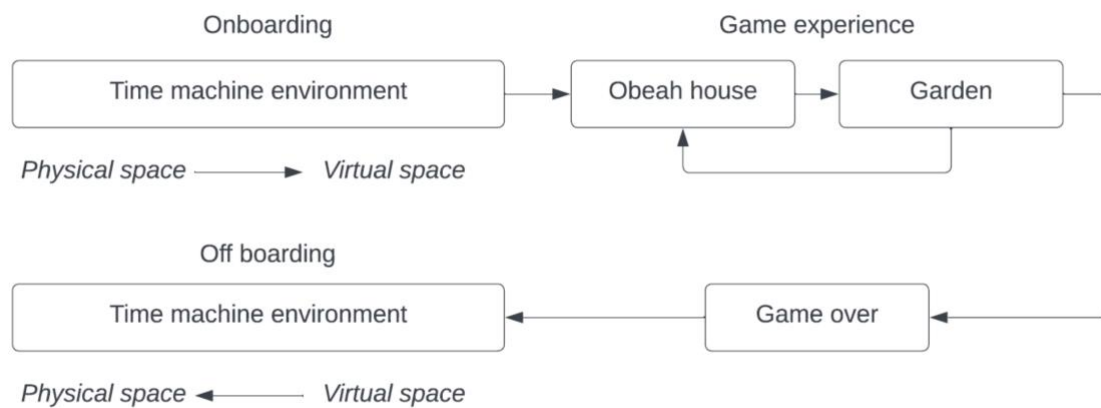
## 2 Concept development

The team explored how Obeah was feared and suppressed by colonial authorities. Obeah ignited considerable fear among the colonialists as it was believed responsible for inciting slave revolts and for maintaining maroon community strength. Legislation against Obeah were passed to not only control the spiritual beliefs of the enslaved africans but also devalue those belief systems. We were moved by the unfairness and disregard for humans and chose to frame the experience around the feeling of unfairness. Illustrated by the concept that whatever choice the player makes, punishment follows.

## 3 Storyline design

Early iterations focused on multiple narrative choices (e.g., joining dances, helping an Obeah, choosing clothing), but later versions streamlined the storyline to emphasize tension, autonomy and a single immersive activity. This was done through a gamified experience where the user needs to help the Obeah by gathering herbs from the garden to make medicine, a practice associated with witchcraft at the time.





#### 4 Mixed reality design

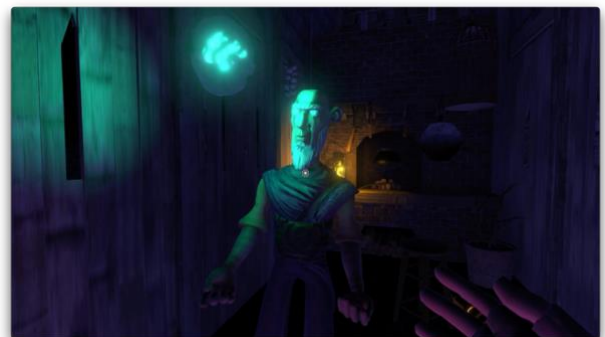
The VR world was designed with key spaces like the Obeah hut, garden with herbs, and guards to shape the atmosphere. Another important aspect of the experience was the mixed reality approach. Some objects were placed both in VR and in the real world such as the time machine portal and a ladle and kettle to stir the medicine. This increased the degree to which users felt immersed.

The experience allowed participants to knock on doors, encounter guards, and risk arrest, building dramatic tension and confronting them with questions about representation, ethics, and historical accuracy.



## 5 Final experience

Employees of the National Archive participated in the VR demo. It started with an onboarding video, then they entered into VR and interacted with an Obeah who asked them to collect herbs in the garden, while avoiding getting caught by the guards. When all herbs were gathered, they were put into a kettle following close instructions of the Obeah. Here the user interacted with a physical ladle and kettle, enhancing the realism of the experience. During the ritual, the experience is abruptly interrupted by guards pounding on the door to catch the Obeah, the user gets the chance to flee back to the real world. Finally, the user is welcomed to a day tea shop; connecting the past, where herbs were a reason for a death sentence, to the present, where herbs are enjoyed in tea without consequence.







*"The level of detail of the entire go through of the experience was magnificent. The finishing touch with the document embedded within the tea bag souvenir was a clear indication of this."*

Robby van Delden, HMI Assistant Professor

## My role

- Team chair which included organising meetings, overview of project and tasks
- Concept development
- Gathering and designing 3D assets and screens
- Designing the memorabilia tea bag the user could take away after the experience as a reminder of the past, present and future of Curacao's confronting but rich history.

## Lessons learnt

- A strong, focused concept is more valuable than chasing multiple ideas.
- Move from ideation to iteration quickly to test and refine concepts.
- Prioritize core interactions and storytelling
- VR experiences require well thought out onboarding design